

The Hearth Ledger

Tales of the Threshold

Told by the fires of Fate's Edge

Set down by *Dusana of the Raven Road*

Under the lamp, bread and salt. The ink is ash and rain.

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Preface: The Road That Listens

A ledger of stories is not a ledger of coin. It balances nothing.

You travel. You sit by fires. A woman speaks. You write. The ash on your cuff becomes ink. That is all.

My people are the Tulkani. We build no temples. Our wagons carry the hearth. Kuva rides the storm – some say. I have lit a candle for him when the road was ice. Kuva counts the stars; I count the thresholds.

Ikasha does not command. She sleeps. Between her breaths, there is room for secrets. I have borrowed that space.

These tales were told by midwives, bell-wardens, hedge-mothers, cord-weavers. They did not call themselves witches. The women who speak to the dead never do.

I wrote as the fire guttered. Where a teller coughed, I left a space. Where a bell rang, I marked the hour. Where the ninth word was missing – I did not add it.

Some tales are comfort. Some are warnings. A few are keys.

Read them. Or don't. The road turns regardless.

— *Dusana of the Raven Road*

Under the lamp, bread and salt. The ink is ash and rain.

I **The Vent That Whispered**

Told by

Old Orra, lamp-keeper of the Third Stack, Aelerian Range.
Not been underground in thirty years, but still counts her
breaths before sleep.

The Tale

You ever walk the Deep Galleries alone? No? Good.
Don't start.

The air down there has a ledger. Eight breaths is a
corridor. Sixteen is a chamber. Thirty-two is a fool who
forgot to turn back. That's what they taught me. Breathe,
count, turn. Never answer the ninth.

I was young. Lamp trimmed, chalk dry. Third Stack
to the old sump. Easy walk. Should've been two hours.

At the junction – you know the one, three tunnels,
the middle one always drips – I stopped. Something was
wrong. The drip had stopped. The echo had changed.
And then I heard it.

Not with my ears. Inside. Like a memory that wasn't
mine.

"Count the ninth breath."

I didn't. I walked. The voice followed.

*"The ninth holds the name of the miner who died here.
The year the pillar cracked. The route to the lost sump."*

My lamp flickered. I didn't stop to trim it. I kept counting. Eight in. Eight out. My lips moved. The voice couldn't get in.

When I reached the surface, the lamp was dry. My shadow was gone. The next morning I looked in a mirror and the reflection smiled first.

Took a week for the shadow to come back. Took another for my left hand to stop writing in a script I couldn't read. The Vent-Prior said the deep had spoken and I hadn't answered, and that was mercy.

She promoted me to lamp-keeper. I never went down again.

The Witch's Closing

"Stone remembers. So does the space between breaths. Answer neither. And if you must walk the deep, count to eight – then start over."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Voice in the Crack

Description: A psychic remnant of a Deep Drake sealed in the mountain. It cannot move, but it whispers into the minds of those who walk alone in deep, dark, air-starved places. It offers secrets. It asks for the ninth breath.

Tags / Mechanics:

- Tags: [PSIONIC] [DOMAIN (stone)] [DREAD]
- Harm: none directly – mental strain.
- Fatigue: On failed Spirit + Resolve (DV 4), mark 1 Fatigue and hear a false memory.
- Clock: *Counting the Ninth* [4] – ticks each time a character answers a question while alone in the dark. When full, lose shadow for 1d3 days (social Position –1; shadow may act independently).
- Strings: The Voice can offer a *True Shem* – a forgotten fact, lost name, or route through stone – in exchange for counting the ninth breath (advancing the clock).

Motivation: Feeds on attention and isolation. Wants to be witnessed.

Adventure Hook: A vent-warden has gone missing in the Third Stack. The party finds a crack in the wall – and hears breathing on the other side.

Colophon

Recorded in the Third Stack hostel, winter of 862, by
Dusana of the Raven Road. The chalk circle was erased
before I slept. My shadow arrived a heartbeat late.

A Note on the Telling

The Aeler woman erased the circle with her palm. "Now the forgetting begins," she said.

I wrote quickly. The chalk dust tasted of lime.

– Third Stack hostel, year of the long winter.

2 The Hollow Bride

Told by

Mabs the Miller, a round woman with flour on her apron and a cider-cup always half full. Tells stories while she works the grindstone. Says the Hollow talks to her at night.

The Tale

You know about the ninth cup, don't you? Course you do. Every child knows: you pour eight. You never pour the ninth. The ninth is for the Hollow.

But children forget. Or they get curious. That's how it always starts.

Little Kesta – she was what, seven? – went to the well at dusk. The adults were at the harvest feast. She was supposed to draw water for the morning bread. She counted the buckets: one, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight.

Then she thought: what's one more?

She drew the ninth bucket. The water was black. And something climbed out.

It wore her mother's wedding dress. It smiled with

her mother's mouth. But its eyes were the colour of a drowned moon.

"Hollow Bride," Kesta whispered. That's what the old folk call it. You don't name it. She named it.

The Bride followed her home. It stood outside the red door. It knocked. Three knocks, then a pause, then three more. The rhythm of a heart that stopped.

Kesta's mother opened the door. "Come in," she said. "You must be cold." That's the law of hospitality. A red door means bread, salt, and one safe night.

The Hollow Bride stepped inside. It sat at the table. It didn't eat. It didn't speak. It just watched.

At midnight, it said: "You poured the ninth cup. You named me. Now I am your guest."

The mother understood. She cut a loaf with a knife that had been blessed at the Moot Oak. She put salt on the table with her left hand. She said: "Guest-right lasts one night. At dawn, you leave."

The Hollow Bride smiled. "I will leave," it said. "But I will return. The ninth cup is an invitation. The threshold remembers."

Kesta is an old woman now. She still sets eight cups on her table. She still leaves the ninth empty. And every harvest, when the lanterns burn blue at the ford, she checks the red door. So far, it's held.

The Witch's Closing

"Hospitality is a thread. Tie it right, and it binds the guest. Tie it wrong, and it binds you. And never, ever pour the ninth."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Hollow Bride

Description: A threshold-spirit that wears the face of a loved one. It can only enter a home if invited – either by name, by pouring a ninth cup, or by breaking some other taboo of hospitality.

Tags / Mechanics:

FAE [THRESHOLD] [DREAD]

- Cannot cross a red door unless invited. Repelled by bread, salt, and a blessed knife.
- Harm: none. It imposes Conditions: *Watched*, *Invited*, *Named*.
- Clock: *The Ninth Cup* [6] – ticks each time hospitality is broken. When full, the Bride can enter uninvited.

- **Bargaining:** The Bride may be offered a substitute – a memory, a name, a firstborn child – to buy another year of silence.

Adventure Hook: A village has the same nightmare: a woman in a wedding dress outside a red door, knocking. The party must find who broke guest-right and HEAL the threshold.

Colophon

Recorded in the miller's kitchen, year of the sour harvest.
The kettle was warm. The cider was dry. The Bride did not knock that night.

The Empty Cup

Eight cups. Eight names. The ninth cup missing.

”Count,” the Aelaerem witch said. ”If the ninth is not there, it is not owed.”

She drank from the eighth. The lamp guttered. No ninth.

– *Meadow south of the Valewood, moon forgetting its phase.*

3 **The Warrior Who Refused to Call the Runner**

Told by

Temur Many-Scars, steppe rider with a braid down to his belt and a laugh like breaking bones. Been in more camps than he can count. Says the only thing that kept him alive was bad geometry.

A Note on the Telling

The Ykrul speak of the board with their own tongue. *War-Chief* is the piece others call Blue. *Runner* is Green. *Well* is Sanctum. *Calling a Runner* is Seeding. *Nailed* is Rooted. *The Five-Breath Race* is Reforge. *Cuts* are specials. *Breaths* are plies. *The shadow of the stone* is ZoC.

The Tale

The Khagan called a muster. We were young, hungry, and stupid. My cousin – bold as a winter wolf – wanted glory. He pushed his War-Chief forward. He didn't count exits. He just pushed.

The enemy stepped aside. Let him pass. Let him think he was winning.

By the time he reached the Well, his cuts were spent. He looked at the far Well. It was empty. He could Call a Runner. But his War-Chief would be Nailed for a breath.

I said: "Don't. Their War-Chief still has a cut. They're two breaths away."

He laughed. "They won't risk it."

He Called.

The enemy hopped a stone, landed on the Well, and displaced his War-Chief off the board. Five breaths started ticking. My cousin had to plant his banner in five of his breaths.

He didn't. The enemy had already welded the approach. Every lane ended in the shadow of the stone. The race was dead.

We lost. The clan paid tribute for a year.

The Khagan demoted him to herd-watcher. "You forgot the first number," she said. "Count exits before you count glory. Call only when the geometry is yours."

The Witch's Closing

"A free War-Chief is a noose. Call only when the shadow is yours. Always keep one cut for the door."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Herd-Watcher's Regret (a curse)

Description: A punishment for warriors who Call unsafely. The curse takes reputation, rank, sense of direction. The victim becomes forgettable – still alive but no longer counted.

Tags / Mechanics:

CURSE [SOCIAL] [DREAD]

- –1 Position on Command and Sway.
- Once per session, GM may force a re-roll on Navigation or Tactics (wrong path).
- Strings: Curse lifted by a public act of heroic geometry – winning a Kon'reh match or completing a Five-Breath Race.
- Clock: *Forgotten Name* [6] – when full, the victim loses their name entirely. No one remembers them.

Adventure Hook: A decorated warrior has disappeared from the camp ledger. She still sits by the fire, but everyone looks past her. Restore her name.

Colophon

Winter camp of the Grey Fox clan. The rider spat tea leaves into the fire. "That was the winter I learned to count."

The Count

The Ykrul woman held up eight fingers. Then one fist.

”Nine is not a number,” she said. ”It is a wound that hasn’t closed.”

– *Winter camp, Grey Fox clan, year the passes froze.*

4 The Silk Witness

Told by

Maer of the Root-Circle, a graying wood elf who mends bridges and remembers every broken oath. Speaks like water over stones – soft, but sharp.

The Tale

A merchant came to the Valewood, full of himself and his ledgers. He needed a bridge. He had coin. He did not have courtesy.

He spoke to the Lethai-al wardens. "Name your price," he said. "Double if you build it by autumn."

They sent for the Silk Vigil. The Vigil hung a thread across the river. White silk, thin as a spider's. "Cross this," they said, "and we will talk."

The merchant laughed and stepped over.

The thread broke.

The Vigil nodded. "You have refused witness. Build your bridge. Every plank will remember your rudeness. No one will sing its name."

He built it. It held. Workers called it "the Rudeness." Travellers spat on its railings.

Years later, he returned, bent and grey. He knelt. "What must I pay?"

The Vigil picked up a single strand. "Say: "I am sorry for the courtesy I broke." Then build a garden under the bridge, for the eels to hide in."

He did. The eels came. The bridge softened. Now they sing of it – not as a curse, but as a repair.

The Witch's Closing

"Mercy with memory. That is the thread. Cut it, and you build alone. HEAL it, and the road belongs to everyone."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Unwitnessed Bridge

A bridge built without proper rites – no thread, no witness. Sound, but radiates a low social curse. Those who cross feel irritation, suspicion.

Tags / Mechanics:

CURSE [LOCATION] [SOCIAL]

- –1 Position on social rolls on or near the bridge.

- Once per day, GM may force a re-roll on Command or Sway while crossing.
- Clock: *Repair the Bridge* [6] – needs an offering of courtesy (bread, salt, an apology) and a public act of repair.

Adventure Hook: A new bridge divides a river community. Merchants whisper of bad luck. The builder died without apologising. HEAL the crossing.

Colophon

Sat under a roof-tree at the edge of the Root-Circle. The eels were listening.

The Thread

The Lethai-al woman held up a strand of silk. "This is a promise," she said. "It breaks when you lie."

At the end of the story, it was still whole.

– *Root-Circle, autumn equinox.*

5 The Gloss That Ate a Name

Told by

Archivist Venn, a high elf with ink under her nails and a voice that never rises above a murmur. Says she's forgotten more languages than most people learn.

The Tale

In the great library of Thepyrgos, there is a scroll that rewrites itself. Copied from a copy from a copy, each margin a correction, each correction a new error.

A scholar – Mira – wanted the original. Archivists refused. "The original is lost."

She found a forbidden room. Inside, a single scroll sealed with wax not warm for a thousand years. She broke the seal.

The scroll was blank.

Weeks passed. Mira began to forget her own name. Students' faces blurred. Mother's voice became a hum. She returned. The scroll now held one word: *Mira*.

She understood. The scroll did not store knowledge. It *ate* it. The copy was safety. The original was hunger.

She burned it. The fire was cold. The smoke smelled

of forgotten birthdays. Her name returned – but not her grandmother’s face. That was the toll.

The Witch’s Closing

”Context is a key. Lose the key, lose the door. Lose the door, lose yourself.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Hungry Scroll

Ancient artifact that erases memory. Appears as a blank parchment in a sealed case. Reader loses specific memories – names, faces, skills.

Tags / Mechanics:

CURSE [KNOWLEDGE] [DREAD]

- On reading, test Spirit + Resolve (DV 5). Failure: lose one memory (player chooses a minor fact).
- Clock: *Erasure* [8]. When full, victim forgets own name and cannot form new long-term memories.
- Destroyed only with fire from a living witness (a bell, a lamp, a human breath).

Adventure Hook: A scholar has gone missing. Her notes are contradictions. In her study, a blank scroll on a lectern. Read it, burn it, or seal it – knowing someone else will find it.

Colophon

Copied from a margin note in a banned book. The archivist would not let me see her face. The ink was still wet.

The Blank Page

The high elf pointed to a page in her ledger. "This is where the name was," she said.

The paper was smooth. No erasure. Just a space.

– *Thepyrgos, scriptorium at midnight.*

6 The Bargain of the Shed Skin

Told by

Serpent-keeper Ashai, a dark elf with scales tattooed up her arms and a voice like a knife wrapped in silk. Says she's shed three names already.

The Tale

A woman came to the Coil Court. "I gave a Lethai-ar my fear of the dark. Now I cannot sleep. Faces in the shadows not my own."

The serpent-queen nodded. "You paid for a shedding. You received it. The price is not your fear. It is your solitude."

The woman wept. "I did not know."

"You did not ask."

She offered a second bargain. "Shed this solitude. Forget the faces. Forget your mother's lullaby. Owe a favor to the Coil Court."

The woman agreed. She shed. She slept. A year later, a messenger came. "A child has been born without a shadow. Nurse it until the shadow returns."

She nursed for seven years. The shadow never re-

CHAPTER 6. THE BARGAIN OF THE SHED SKIN

turned. The child grew strange – calm, watchful, always polite. When the mother died, the child shed its own name and joined the Coil Court.

The woman was free. But she often looked at her hands and wondered whose heartbeat she was counting.

The Witch's Closing

"A shedding does not erase the debt. It only changes the skin."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Shadowless Child

A child born without a shadow – an old bargain unpaid. Unnervingly calm, immune to fear, can walk thresholds that bar others. May be a vessel for something older.

Tags / Mechanics:

FAE [THRESHOLD] [DREAD]

- Immune to fear. Cannot be compelled by emotion-targeting magic.
- –1 Position on Stealth near the child (shadows are thinner).

- Cannot be harmed by any creature that casts a shadow (convert Harm to Fatigue).
- Clock: *Return the Shadow* [8] – find the original bargain and either fulfil or break it.

Adventure Hook: A village is terrorised by a child who never sleeps, never blinks, and knows everyone's secrets. The child has no shadow – taken by a Lethai-ar who now wants it back.

Colophon

Recorded in a Coil Court antechamber, with warm milk and bitter herbs. The serpent-queen did not look at me once.

CHAPTER 6. THE BARGAIN OF THE SHED SKIN

The Shed Skin

The dark elf peeled a flake of dead skin from her forearm and placed it in the fire.

It did not burn. It curled into the shape of a hand.

"That belonged to a liar," she said. "Now it belongs to no one."

– *Coil Court, after midnight.*

CHAPTER 6. THE BARGAIN OF THE SHED SKIN

7 **The Selkie's Oath**

Told by

Captain Rana of the Eel-Skiff, a Linn woman with salt-bleached braids and a laugh like waves on shingle. Never goes ashore without a knife.

The Tale

A selkie married a fisherman. She gave the usual bargain: hide the skin, she stays. Lose it, she leaves.

He hid it under the hearthstone. Ten years, children, mended nets, quiet storms.

Then the child fell ill. Blood in the cough. The nearest healer was a day's sail. The fisherman hesitated. If he left, the skin unguarded. If he stayed, the child died.

The selkie reached under the hearthstone, pulled out the skin, and cut it into strips.

"Bandages," she said. "The child's breath is worth more than my freedom."

She wrapped the child's chest. The fever broke. The skin was ruined.

At dawn, the fisherman asked, "Will you leave?"

She touched his cheek. "I have no skin to return to. But I have a new oath: I choose to stay."

They say she grew webbing between her fingers the next winter, and her eyes turned the colour of the deep. But she stayed.

The Witch's Closing

"Oaths change. So do the skins we wear. The sea doesn't care which – only that you choose."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Cut Skin

A ruined selkie skin, now a patchwork of bandages. Heals any wound, but transfers selkie nature to the user – webbed fingers, taste for raw fish, longing for the sea.

Tags / Mechanics:

HEAL [CURSE]

- Heals 1 Harm per use. User marks 1 Fatigue after each use (the sea calls).
- Clock: *Sea-Change* [4]. When full, user gains a permanent minor mutation (webbed digits, salt-caked

skin, moon-lit eyes). Cannot be removed without a full renaming ritual.

Adventure Hook: A healer's bandages cure any sickness – but her patients dream of drowned cities. The source: a cut selkie skin. Destroy it or keep the miracle.

Colophon

Told on the deck of the Eel-Skiff, rain coming. The captain spat over the rail. "That's the truth."

The Cloak

The Linn woman's sealskin cloak lay across her knees. She did not touch it. The story ended. The cloak had moved three inches toward the door.

– *Thing-holm, herring run.*

8 The Peddler's Swerve

Told by

Rusti the Factor, a Vilihari trader with a missing finger and a smile that never reaches her eyes. She's sold the same horse three times and still owns it.

The Tale

A peddler came to a border ford. The toll was high. She had no coin. She had a cart full of empty barrels.

"Air," she told the toll-keeper. "Fresh mountain air. The valley pays handsomely."

He laughed. "Air? I'll let you pass for a taste."

She uncorked a barrel, held it to his nose. Pine and snow.

He waved her through.

The next day, a rival told him the barrels were empty. Furious, he rode after her.

She had already sold the air – as "breathing lessons for the rich." Copper per lungful. The barrels were now full of gold.

He cornered her. "You cheated me."

She shrugged. "Air is free. You chose not to sell it. I did."

She paid double the original toll – from the gold – and asked, "Do you want a lesson in breathing?"

He did not. But the next year, he sold fog to the lowlands. Made a fortune.

The Witch's Closing

"Sell the hour, not the horse. Value is not in the thing – it is in the need."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Hollow Barrel

A barrel that appears empty but can be "filled" with anything people believe is inside. Works by suggestion – open it, describe the contents, it emits faint scent, sound, warmth. Cannot create matter, only perception.

Tags / Mechanics:

ILLUSION [TRICK]

- Once per scene, a character can declare the barrel contains a plausible small object. It produces sensory evidence. Perception DV 3 reveals illusion.

- Used to fool guards, start rumours, create false trails.

Adventure Hook: A con artist is selling "dragon's breath" and "ghost tears" using hollow barrels. Catch her – or join her.

Colophon

Recorded in a Vilikari waystation, bad wine and good lies.
The factor winked. "You'll sell that one day," pointing at my notebook.

The Barrel

The Vilikari woman tapped a barrel. It rang hollow. "Opportunity," she said. "Every empty thing is a chance to fill it with story."

– *Waystation south of the Violet Bazaar.*

9 The Censor's Mask

Told by

Old Censor Varo, a man with one eye and a brand on his cheek. He sits by the forum fountain and feed the pigeons. Children dare each other to ask him about the mask.

The Tale

The Censor of Ecktoria wears a mask. It is old, bronze, with eyeholes that see through lies. He wears it only at the Triumph, when petitioners approach.

One year, a merchant offered a bribe. The Censor refused. The merchant insisted. The Censor removed the mask.

The merchant screamed. The mask had no face inside. Only a whisper: "I have seen your ledgers."

The merchant fled. The Censor put the mask back on. At the next Triumph, he wore it again.

But he dreamed that night of his own lies – the grain he had skimmed, the witness he had ignored. The mask had seen him too.

He tried to remove it. It would not come off. He cut the straps. It stayed. He broke the bronze. It reformed.

For a year he wore the mask, unable to eat or drink, but did not starve. The mask fed on his guilt.

On the next Triumph, he knelt before the assembly. "I am unworthy," he said. "Judge me."

The mask fell off. His face was younger. His eye was whole.

He became the most honest Censor the city ever had. He never wore the mask again. He did not need to.

The Witch's Closing

"Judgment begins at home. The mask only shows what you already know."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Censor's Mask

A bronze mask that reveals the wearer's own hidden crimes. It cannot be removed until the wearer confesses publicly. While worn, the wearer cannot eat or drink but does not die – sustained by guilt.

Tags / Mechanics:

CURSE [TRUTH]

- Wearer gains +2 dice to Insight against deception. But at the end of each scene, they must confess a secret flaw (GM may ask "what guilt does the mask show you?"). On refusal, clock *Confession* [4] ticks.
- When clock fills, the wearer is compelled to make a public confession. After confession, the mask can be removed.

Adventure Hook: A city official has stopped eating. He speaks in whispers, and a bronze mask has fused to his face. The party must learn what he did – and persuade him to confess before he wastes away.

Colophon

Forum fountain, late winter. The old man threw a crust to a pigeon. "I was his clerk," he said. "I forged the ledgers. He wore the mask for both of us."

The Mask

The old man touched his cheek. "The brand is where the mask bit," he said. "It has no teeth. But it remembers."

– *Ecktoria, fountain of the four rivers.*

10 The Bride of Nine Knots

Told by

Lady Ysoria, a Vhasian widow who lives in a red tower and receives visitors only at dusk. Her left hand has six fingers. She says the extra one was a wedding gift.

The Tale

A bride tied her dowry rope with nine knots. One for each year she waited for her betrothed. The priest said, "Eight is custom. Ninth is a weapon."

She tied it anyway.

At the wedding, her rival – who had also loved the groom – stepped forward and cut the ninth knot.

The groom forgot his vows. He stood silent, mouth open, eyes vacant. The bride spoke for him: "I give this ring. I take this name. I close this door."

The priest nodded. The bond held.

But the rival's hand withered where she had cut the cord. The bride kept the severed knot in a locket. On her deathbed, she gave it to her daughter.

"If you ever need to silence a liar," she said, "cut a knot. But be sure you know whose tongue will still speak

afterwards.”

The Witch’s Closing

”The ninth knot is the thread that holds. Cut it, and the story unravels. But the blade cuts both ways.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Ninth Knot

A piece of wedding cord that can be used to ”un-speak” a single vow or promise. When cut, the target forgets the specific promise they made. The cutter’s hand withers for a year (cannot hold weapons or tools without pain). The knot regrows after a season.

Tags / Mechanics:

CURSE [TRUTH]

- As an action, cut the knot and name a vow. The target loses all memory of that vow. The cutter suffers –1 die on all physical rolls using their dominant hand for 1 month (in-game time).
- The knot can be used once per season.

Adventure Hook: A noble has been forced into a marriage contract she does not want. She possesses a ninth knot – but cutting it will also destroy the trust her family has in her. The party must decide: cut the knot, or find another way.

Colophon

Red tower, dusk. The widow poured wine into eight cups. The ninth she emptied on the floor. "For the ones who forgot," she said.

The Knot

The Vhasian woman held up a piece of frayed rope. "This was my grandmother's," she said. "She cut it twice. Once for love. Once for hate. The rope remembers both."

– *Red tower, Vhasian border.*

II The Gate That Asked a Question

Told by

Old Hedge-warden Cormac, a man who leans on a staff and speaks only in rulings. He has judged more boundary disputes than the queen.

The Tale

A traveller came to a gate. It was old stone, moss-grown, with a single bell hanging from the lintel.

The gate-keeper sat on a stool, whittling a stick. "What is the weight of a road?" he asked.

The traveller thought. "The weight of the stone beneath it."

The gate-keeper shook his head. The bell did not ring.

The traveller tried again. "The weight of the coin paid for it."

The bell remained silent.

A third answer: "The weight of the promise that keeps it open."

The bell rang once. The gate opened.

The gate-keeper said, "A road has no weight. It is permission. Permission can be withdrawn. So be courteous, or walk elsewhere."

The traveller passed. Behind him, the gate-keeper erased a chalk mark from the stone. A boundary had moved.

The Witch's Closing

"Law is not stone. It is consent. Consent can be withdrawn. So speak softly, and keep your promises."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Wandering Gate

A gate that appears only at twilight, at different boundaries. It asks a riddle of each traveller. Wrong answers: it disappears. Right answer: the traveller may cross, and the gate moves a boundary stone one inch in the direction the traveller came from – slowly reshaping property lines.

Tags / Mechanics:

THRESHOLD [MYSTERY]

- To find the gate, a character must be lost at dusk and succeed on a Wisdom + Survival test (DV 4).

The gate appears.

- The riddle is always a moral question about boundaries, property, or promises. The GM may ask the player to answer in character. No roll – the answer must be judged by the GM as "true" or "false" based on the character's past actions.
- If correct, the gate opens and may move a boundary stone. If incorrect, the character cannot cross that threshold for a year.

Adventure Hook: A farmer's field has shrunk overnight. His neighbour claims the boundary moved. The party must find the wandering gate and answer its riddle before the dispute becomes a blood feud.

Colophon

At a hedge-moot, twilight. The old warden pointed a stick at a chalk line. "That's where I moved it," he said. "He never noticed."

The Gate

The Viterran man tapped the lintel with his staff. "This gate has heard a thousand lies," he said. "It opens only for the ones who admit they don't know."

– *Hedge-moot, border of Fenwood.*

12 The Stair That Was Not

Told by

Scholar Lyra, who never leaves the library and reads by candlelight. Her handwriting is too small to read without a lens. She says that is intentional.

The Tale

A student climbed a stair in the Collegium of Keys. He had counted the steps: one, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight.

Then the ninth. There was no ninth. The stair continued anyway.

He climbed until his legs ached. The walls changed from stone to vellum to glass. The steps became sentences. The banisters became arguments.

At the top, a desk. On it, a single page. It was his own thesis – corrected.

He read the corrections. They were right. He had been wrong. He wept.

When he looked up, the desk was gone. The stair was gone. He was standing in the basement, holding a piece of chalk.

He never told anyone what the corrections said. But his next thesis was perfect. And he never climbed a stair without counting twice.

The Witch's Closing

"A proof that cannot be improved is already dead. The stair judges. Accept its edits, or stay in the basement."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Invisible Stair

A stair that appears only to those who have made a significant intellectual error. It leads to a room where their mistake is made manifest. To leave, they must admit the error aloud. Denial traps them until they speak true.

Tags / Mechanics:

TRUTH [DREAM]

- Trigger: a character fails a Lore or Investigation roll by 5 or more. The stair appears in the next room they enter.
- To climb, they must succeed a Will + Lore test (DV 6). Failure: they climb but cannot reach the top

until they solve the puzzle (GM presents a riddle based on the failed skill check). After solving, they gain +1 die to all future rolls of that skill (insight from the correction).

Adventure Hook: A scholar's maps have been wrong for decades. She has hidden her error by avoiding the region. The party must find the invisible stair, correct the map, and face whatever the truth has done to the people who lived there.

Colophon

Scriptorium of the Collegium, midnight. The scholar held up a lens. "See the margin?" she said. "That's where the stair begins."

The Stair

The Thepyrgosi scholar pointed to a blank space on the page. "That's where the ninth step used to be," she said. "It moved."

– *Collegium of Keys, after curfew.*

13 **The Lantern That Remem- bered**

Told by

Pilot Seref, a woman with one eye and a brass hook for a hand. She captains a little cutter called the *Red Wake*. Says the sea tells her where to go.

The Tale

A young pilot lit a beacon on the headland. It was his first night alone. He trimmed the lamp, checked the mirror, poured oil. The flame burned steady.

At midnight, the beacon spoke. "I have seen this coast for three hundred years," it said. "I remember every ship that broke."

The pilot asked, "What do you want?"

"I want someone to listen. Then I want someone to change the light."

The pilot listened. He heard of wrecks, of storms, of pilots who died with their codes still secret. Then he climbed the tower and turned the lantern one degree east.

The beacon fell silent. The next morning, a ship that

would have wrecked passed safely.

The pilot was promoted. He never told anyone about the voice. But every time he lit a new beacon, he spoke to it first. "I am listening," he said. "Tell me when to move."

The Witch's Closing

"Beacons are not marks. They are arguments. If you do not listen, they will argue without you."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Speaking Beacon

An old lighthouse whose flame is alive. It remembers every ship that has wrecked nearby. It can see storms days before they arrive. It will share its knowledge only with those who listen – and who are willing to adjust the lantern's angle by a few degrees, changing the safe channel.

Tags / Mechanics:

KNOWLEDGE [LOCATION]

- A character who spends a night in the beacon and succeeds on Spirit + Lore (DV 4) gains a vision of the next storm's path (+1 die to navigation for the next leg).

- The beacon may also reveal the location of a sunken wreck (a clue or treasure).
- If the lantern is moved without the beacon's consent, the beacon goes dark for a month and the pilot gains a reputation as "deaf".

Adventure Hook: A coastal beacon has gone dark. Ships are wrecking on a reef that was never there before. The party must discover why the lighthouse is silent – and whether the beacon is hiding something, or grieving something.

Colophon

On the *Red Wake*, at anchor. The pilot spat into the waves. "She's been quiet since the war," she said. "I think she's waiting for someone."

The Beacon

The pilot pointed to a distant light. "See how it flickers?" she said. "That's not wind. That's memory."

– *Off the Red Shoal, night.*

14 **The Bell That Never Rang**

Told by

Bell-warden Hollis, a gaunt man with soot under his fingernails and a cough that never quite stops. He tends the levee bells alone.

The Tale

A bell was cast for a tower in the Mistlands. It was large, bronze, etched with ward-runes. The smith said, "Ring it once, and the fog retreats. Ring it twice, and the dead listen. Ring it thrice, and the Direwood speaks."

The warden hung it. He never rang it. He polished it. He oiled the clapper. He counted the hours without sound.

When the fog rose, the villagers pleaded. "Ring the bell!"

He refused. "It is not time."

When a child was lost, they begged. "Ring it! The dead will help us find her."

He refused. "The dead do not help. They collect."

When the grey wraiths came, the villagers fled. The warden stayed. He climbed the tower. He did not ring the

bell. He stood beside it, arms spread, and said nothing.

The wraiths passed. The tower stood. The bell never rang.

When they found the warden, he was dead. His hands were clasped around the clapper. He had kept it silent even as his breath left.

They buried him under the tower. The bell still hangs. No one has rung it.

The Witch's Closing

"Some warnings should never be spoken. The bell knows. So did he."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Silent Bell

A bell that rings only when its guardian dies. It will ring once, and its note is so pure that it banishes all fog and ghosts within a mile for a full day. After that, the bell cracks. It can be used only once.

Tags / Mechanics:

WARD [SACRIFICE]

- To ring the bell, a character must die while touching it. The bell tolls once, clearing all supernatural threats in a large area (GM discretion). The bell is then destroyed.
- A character may attempt to ring it without dying by succeeding on a Body + Resolve test (DV 6) – but they suffer 3 Harm (and may still die). On success, the bell rings, they live, and the bell cracks but can be repaired (cost and time).

Adventure Hook: An old bell-warden lies dying. The fog is rising, and the dead are walking. He has never told anyone the bell's secret. The party must decide: ring it and lose it, or find another way – and perhaps become the next keepers of the silent tower.

Colophon

Levee tower, morning. The warden coughed into his sleeve. "No," he said, when I asked if he would ring it. "Not today."

The Bell

The bell-warden pointed to a crack in the bronze. "That's where the ninth chime was," he said. "Before it learned to keep quiet."

– *Levee tower, dawn.*

15 The Loom of Debts

Told by

Weaver Thalia, a woman with red-stained fingers and a loom that never stops. She weaves shrouds for the guild.

The Tale

A dyer bought a bolt of silk from a merchant. It was white, heavy, cool to the touch. The merchant said, "This silk remembers every shame it has witnessed. Weave with care."

The dyer did not believe him. He dyed the silk crimson and cut it into lengths for the market.

But the silk would not leave the loom. It rewound itself at night. The threads knotted into faces. The faces whispered confessions.

The dyer tried to burn it. The fire turned the silk black, and the confessional grew louder.

A witch came. She touched the loom. "You did not buy the silk," she said. "You bought the witness. It will not leave until you confess."

The dyer knelt. He admitted his shames – the false weights, the watered dyes, the apprentice he had blamed

for his own mistake.

The silk loosened. The witch cut a single thread. "This is your toll," she said. "Wear it as a bracelet. When you lie, it tightens."

The dyer wore the thread for the rest of his life. He never lied again. The silk was sold for a fair price – and the buyer was told its nature.

The Witch's Closing

"What you hide may hold you. Confess, or be woven into the cloth."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Witness Silk

A bolt of silk that retains memory of every wrong witnessed in its presence. It cannot be destroyed by normal fire. To unbind it, someone must confess a secret shame in front of it. The confession frees one yard of silk at a time.

Tags / Mechanics:

TRUTH [CURSE]

- A character who possesses the silk gains +1 to Insight rolls (the silk whispers hints). But at each downtime, the GM may ask for a confession (a minor flaw, a forgotten debt). If refused, the silk tightens: the character suffers –1 die on all social rolls until they confess.
- The silk can be "paid off" by sacrificing a yard (which becomes inert cloth) in exchange for a favor from a guild or spirit.

Adventure Hook: A merchant's best loom is stuck – the silk will not come out. The merchant is hiding a secret that could ruin him. The party must decide: extract the confession, burn the loom, or find a third way.

Colophon

Weaver's loft, dusk. The loom clicked. Thalia touched a thread. "This one is mine," she said. "I overcharged a widow. The silk remembers."

The Thread

The weaver held up a crimson strand. "This was dyed with guilt," she said. "It never fades."

– *Silkstrand, dye ward.*

16 The Coin That Came Back

Told by

Old Salt, a Zakov pirate with a peg leg and a parrot that swears in three languages. He's been drowned twice. The sea spit him out both times.

The Tale

A smuggler found a coin in a dead man's eye. It was silver, warm to the touch, stamped with a ship that had no name. He took it.

That night, the coin bought him safe passage past a patrol. The watchman looked at it and waved him through without a word.

The next day, the dead man's ghost sat in his cargo hold. "You took my toll," the ghost said. "Now you owe me passage."

The smuggler tried to sell the coin. No one would take it. He tried to throw it overboard. It floated back. He tried to give it to a beggar. The beggar returned it at dawn.

He sailed to a shrine of the drowned. He placed the coin on the altar. The ghost appeared again. "Not enough,"

it said. "You must carry me to the place I died."

The smuggler sailed to a reef. He dropped the coin into the water. The ghost smiled, took the coin, and vanished.

The smuggler sailed home. His hold was full of fish – more than he had ever caught. He never picked up a coin from a dead man's eye again.

The Witch's Closing

"Not all treasure is worth its weight. Some coins carry a ticket. The ticket is always for where you do not want to go."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Ferry Coin

A silver coin taken from a corpse's eye. It cannot be spent, given away, or destroyed. It forces the holder to carry the ghost of the dead person to the place of their death. Once there, the coin and ghost vanish, and the holder is granted a boon of the sea (good fishing, calm waters, a safe passage).

Tags / Mechanics:

CURSE [SACRIFICE]

- The holder gains +1 die on all Negotiation rolls (the coin whispers) but suffers nightmares every night unless they are actively sailing toward the ghost's destination.
- The ghost can be negotiated with – it might accept a substitute voyage (e.g., delivering a message instead of carrying the body). This requires a Will + Lore test (DV 5).

Adventure Hook: A sailor has a coin that won't let him sleep. He doesn't know whose ghost it is. The party must help him discover the dead person's identity and their destination – before the ghost drives him mad.

Colophon

Zakov tavern, the *Drowned Rat*. Old Salt flipped a coin to the barkeep. "That's a live one," he said. "Keep the change."

The Coin

The pirate held up a silver disk. "See the ship?" he said.

"No name. That's how you know it's a death charter."

– *The Drowned Rat, Zakov.*

17 The Veil and the Cradle

Told by

Vizier's widow, a woman who wears a mask even inside her own home. She speaks through a silk curtain. No one has seen her face in twenty years.

The Tale

A slave girl was bought for the sultan's harem. She was young, frightened, and silent. The sultan's wife took pity on her.

"Wear a veil," the wife said. "The sultan will not see you. He sees only the silk. You may become invisible."

The girl wore the veil. She served the sultan's table. He did not see her. She cleaned his chambers. He did not remember her.

One night, the sultan's enemy sent a knife. The girl saw it. She could not call out – her voice would break the veil. She stepped between the knife and the sultan.

She took the blade in her chest. The veil fell. The sultan saw her for the first time.

"Who are you?" he asked.

"The one who was never there," she said. Then she

died.

The sultan had the veil woven into a shroud for her. He kept the shroud for the rest of his life. He never married again.

The Witch's Closing

"The veil hides. The knife reveals. Choose which you carry."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Silent Veil

A silk veil that makes the wearer unnoticeable – not invisible, but forgettable. Guards will look past her; servants will not remember her face. She cannot speak while wearing it, or the effect breaks.

Tags / Mechanics:

STEALTH [CURSE]

- While wearing the veil, the character gains +2 dice to Stealth and Deception to avoid notice. However, they cannot speak (verbal spells, commands, conversation). Removing the veil is an action.

- Each scene, the GM may ask the character to test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4). On failure, the character feels compelled to speak (loudly), breaking the veil and alerting nearby creatures.

Adventure Hook: A noble's daughter has been sold into a hostile court. She has a veil that makes her unnoticeable – but she cannot speak. The party must smuggle her out without being seen, and without her breaking the silence.

Colophon

A room behind a curtain. The widow poured tea. The cup rattled against the saucer. "I wore it for twenty years," she said. "Now I do not need it. The silence is inside me."

The Veil

The widow touched the silk. "I could tell you my name," she said. "But then you would have to forget it." She did not tell me.

– Ashaan, garden of the black fountain.

18 The Ford That Moved

Told by

Ferryman Day, a Dhaharan with a turban and a voice like gravel. He poled his boat across the same ford for fifty years. Says the river changed course three times.

The Tale

A caravan master needed to cross a ford. The river was high, the stones slippery. He prayed to the ford, offering a grain of wheat.

"I will stay still for one crossing," the ford whispered.
"Then you will owe me a name."

He crossed. The ford held.

The next night, he returned. The river was different – deeper, swifter. "Name a price," he said.

"You have already named it," the ford replied. "The name of your firstborn child."

The merchant had no child. He was childless. He began to weep.

The ford softened. "Then give me the name you would have given them. And every year, return and speak it."

The merchant knelt and whispered a name – a name no one had ever heard. The ford calmed. He crossed safely.

He returned every year and spoke the name. His wife gave birth to a daughter. He named her the same name. The ford never troubled him again.

The Witch's Closing

"A road is a covenant. Pay the toll honestly. The river remembers."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Naming Ford

A river crossing that asks for a name as toll. It will accept a false name once – but the next crossing demands the true name of the traveller. If the traveller refuses, the ford shifts its course and becomes impassable for a year.

Tags / Mechanics:

THRESHOLD [TRUTH]

- To cross, a character must succeed on a Spirit + Lore test (DV 3) to recall a name that has meaning. On failure, the ford demands a true name of one of the party. That character then gains a String on

themselves (the ford knows their name) and can be compelled by water magic.

- If the party tries to cross without paying, they must navigate the ford as a hazard (Athletics DV 5) – on failure, they are swept downstream and lose 1 Supply.

Adventure Hook: A ford has closed to all trade. The local lord sent a surveyor; the surveyor returned, but he cannot remember his own name. The party must learn what the ford took – and whether they can pay it back.

Colophon

Ferryman's hut, near the saffron fields. Dav spat into the water. "She's quiet tonight," he said. "Must have taken a good one."

The Ford

The ferryman pointed at a ripple. "That's where the name lives," he said. "It's been there thirty years. It never ages."

– *Dhahara, upper ford.*

19 The Fog Road

Told by

Mist-walker Kell, an old Ubral woman who lives in a cairn and never lights a fire. Says the fog is not a thing; it is a question.

The Tale

A child got lost on the moor. The fog came down thick and grey. She could not see her feet. She walked for hours, but always returned to the same stone.

A voice spoke from the mist. "Who walks on my road?"

"I do," said the child. "I am lost."

"Are you?" said the voice. "You are walking exactly where I need you. But you have not answered my question. Who walks?"

The child thought. She could not give her name – names are for daytime. She could not say her clan – clans are for fires.

"Someone who belongs to the fog," she said.

The voice laughed. "Then you may stay."

The fog parted. The child saw a path of white stones.

She followed it home. At the edge of the moor, she looked back. The fog was gone.

Her grandmother said, "You walked with the Urisk. It asks every traveller the same question. Most answer with their names. Then it keeps them."

The Witch's Closing

"The fog does not hide. It asks if you belong. If you do, it will guide you. If you do not, it will keep you."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Urisk of the Moor

A spirit of the fog. It appears to lost travellers and asks, "Who walks on my road?" If the traveller gives a name, the Urisk learns it and may use it to compel the traveller to stay. If the traveller claims belonging to the fog, the Urisk guides them safely and may become an ally.

Tags / Mechanics:

SPIRIT [THRESHOLD]

- To negotiate with the Urisk, a character must succeed on a Spirit + Lore test (DV 4) while offering a truth about themselves that is not their name (a

memory, a regret, a hope). On success, the Urisk parts the fog and the character may re-roll any failed navigation check on the moor.

- If the character gives their name, the Urisk can later appear as a difficult choice: a Path that seems easy but leads to danger, etc.

Adventure Hook: A shepherd's child has vanished into the fog. The villagers are afraid to search. The party must find the Urisk and answer its question – without losing themselves.

Colophon

Cairn on the high moor. The old woman did not light a candle. "Light attracts the wrong things," she said. "The dark is easier to negotiate with."

The Fog

The Ubral woman pointed to a blank space in the air.
"There," she said. "Do you see it? That's where the Urisk
was standing. It just left."

– *High moor, twilight.*

20 The Counting of the Fifth Breath

Told by

Sergeant Relled, a Black Banner mercenary with a missing ear and a habit of counting his steps. He has survived seven campaigns. He does not know why.

The Tale

A young captain lost his Blue in a skirmish. The enemy had five breaths to plant a banner. The captain panicked.

 "I have four breaths left," he told his sergeant. "What do I do?"

 The sergeant pointed at a ridge. "How many ways up?"

 "Two."

 "Then they are already dead. Weld one. Block the other. Use the first breath to drink water."

 The captain drank. The sergeant welded the path with a line of reds. The enemy runner hesitated. The captain's second breath, he moved an orange to fork the ridge. Third breath, he planted a green on the low path.

Fourth breath, he waited.

The enemy runner never reached the ridge. The fifth breath expired. The captain won.

The sergeant said, "Panic is a debt you cannot afford. Count the breaths. Then count your exits. Then count your water. Then move."

The Witch's Closing

"Re-forge is a budget, not a panic. Spend your first breath on calm. The rest will follow."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Five-Breath Clock

A magical timer that counts down from five (minutes, turns, actions). It appears when a character is in a desperate race – a siege, a chase, a ritual. The character can see the count (a floating number). Each time they act decisively, the clock pauses for a heartbeat. Hesitation makes it tick faster.

Tags / Mechanics:

PRESSURE [DREAD]

- When the clock appears, the character gains +1 die to all actions related to the objective (panic focus) but suffers –1 die to all other actions (tunnel vision).
- If the clock reaches zero, the objective fails. The character can reset the clock by finding a new approach (e.g., a side path, a different tactic), which requires a Vision + Tactics test (DV 4).

Adventure Hook: A mercenary company is trapped in a collapsing fortress. They have five minutes before the enemy arrives. The captain has a magical hourglass that ticks audibly. The party must complete their escape – or find a way to break the clock.

Colophon

Campfire near the Singing Wastes. The sergeant counted his fingers. "Five," he said. "Always check after a fight. You never know when one went missing."

The Count

The mercenary held up five fingers. "This is what a battle is," he said. "Five breaths. Use them well."

– *Black Banner camp, dawn.*

*CHAPTER 20. THE COUNTING OF THE FIFTH
BREATH*

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21 The Saffron Gate

Told by

Merchant Zara, a Fhara woman who wears bells on her ankles and never haggles at the first offer. She says patience is a type of geometry.

The Tale

A merchant came to the Saffron Gate. It was high, carved with lions, guarded by two men who did not blink.

”Toll is one truth,” said the gate.

The merchant offered, ”I am honest.”

The gate did not open.

He offered, ”My goods are pure.”

The gate did not open.

He offered, ”I have never cheated a customer.”

The gate swung open. Inside, a woman sat on a stool. ”You have just told three truths,” she said. ”The first was a boast. The second was a claim. The third was a lie. The gate only opens for lies.”

The merchant stared. ”Then what is the toll?”

”The knowledge that you are a liar,” said the woman. ”Now pass. And remember: the gate knows when you

believe your own stories.”

The Witch’s Closing

”A lie that you believe is not a lie. It is a cage. The gate opens from the inside.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Truth Gate

A magical gate that opens only when a character speaks a falsehood they genuinely believe – not a deliberate lie, but a self-deception. Once opened, the character gains a small epiphany (a realisation that they were wrong about something important). The gate can be used only once per person.

Tags / Mechanics:

TRUTH [THRESHOLD]

- A character must declare a ”truth” about themselves that is actually false. The GM may ask the player to describe the belief. If the GM judges that the character genuinely believes it, the gate opens.

The character then gains +1 die to Insight rolls regarding that specific subject (they have seen their own blind spot).

- The gate will not open for obvious lies or boasts.

Adventure Hook: A diplomat has been sent to open a sealed pass – but the gate requires a self-deception. The diplomat believes she is the best negotiator in the land. She is not. The party must help her see the truth, or find a way to trick the gate.

Colophon

Saffron bazaar, afternoon. Zara counted coins into eight piles. The ninth she left empty. "For the lie I believe," she said.

The Gate

The Fhara woman touched the padlock on her chest. "This is the gate I carry," she said. "It only opens when I admit I am wrong."

– *Saffron bazaar, after trading.*

22 **The Grain That Spoke**

Told by

Granary-keeper Oris, a heavy man with a gentle voice and a ledger that never balances. Says the silo talks to him when the wheat is low.

The Tale

A clerk was tallying grain in the silo. He counted aloud: one sack, two sacks, three, four, five, six, seven, eight.

”Ninth,” whispered the grain.

He stopped. He had been taught: never count the ninth. He looked. The grain had shifted. A single kernel lay on the floor.

He picked it up. It was warm. He put it in his pocket.

That night, he dreamed of debtors. Their names were scratched into his ledger. He woke and forgave three.

The next day, the grain was heavier. He counted again. Eight sacks. The ninth was full of light.

He forgave another debtor. The grain remained full.

For a year, he forgave one debtor each night. The granary never emptied. The villagers called it a miracle. The clerk said, ”It is a conversation.”

When he died, they found the kernel in his hand. It had grown into a small, green shoot. They planted it by the silo. The grain never spoke again.

The Witch's Closing

"Mercy enriches the giver. The grain knows. It counts only the eighth name – the one you chose to spare."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Speaking Grain

A silo of grain that whispers the names of those who are in debt. The grain can be used to "pay" a debt – by forgiving the debtor, the grain replenishes itself. If the owner uses the grain for profit instead of mercy, the silo empties.

Tags / Mechanics:

HEAL [TRUTH]

- Once per week, the grain reveals one name of someone who owes a debt (material, emotional, or magical). The owner may choose to forgive that debt. The grain then produces 1 Supply (as if a new shipment arrived).

- If the owner chooses to collect the debt instead, the grain becomes stale and provides no benefit for a month.

Adventure Hook: A village granary is overflowing despite a drought. The keeper is growing rich – but he has stopped forgiving debts. The party must learn the secret of the grain and decide whether the miracle is worth the price.

Colophon

Granary, evening. Oris held up a single kernel. "This is the first one," he said. "It still speaks. But I do not listen anymore."

The Grain

The granary-keeper poured a handful of wheat into my palm. "Count it," he said.

I counted eight.

"Good," he said. "There is no ninth. That is the mercy."

– *Osbeira, river silo.*

23 **The Bargain of the Unlit Lamp**

Told by

A Trow who gave no name. It sat in the corner of the tavern, smoking a pipe that had no ember. Its voice was dry leaves. I wrote what I heard.

The Tale

A traveller came to a crossroads at midnight. A figure waited there. It wore a grey robe and a hat that drank the starlight.

”I am a Trow,” it said. ”I trade in absence. What do you lack?”

The traveller lacked nothing. He was wealthy, happy, loved.

”Then sell me something you do not need,” said the Trow. ”A memory. A breath. A name you have never used.”

The traveller laughed and sold his left-handed glove.

The Trow gave him a lamp that would never go out. ”The light will not fade,” it said. ”But you will forget why you needed it.”

The traveller took the lamp. He walked home. The

light guided him. But when he arrived, he could not remember his wife's face. He could not remember the way to his own door.

He returned to the crossroads. The Trow was gone. He found his glove on the ground. He put it on. The lamp went out.

He sat in the dark, remembering. The next morning, he left the lamp at the crossroad and walked away. He never bought from a Trow again.

The Witch's Closing

"Trow trade in gaps. The gap that light fills is the gap where memory used to be."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Trow Lamp

A lantern that never needs oil and never goes out – but each hour it burns, the user loses a random memory (a face, a word, a route). Once lit, it cannot be extinguished except by returning the price paid (which the Trow will accept only once).

Tags / Mechanics:

LIGHT [CURSE]

- The lamp provides perfect illumination in a 30-foot radius. Every hour, the GM erases one minor fact from the character's background (the character may still remember, but the fact is "blank" – they cannot recall it under pressure). After 8 hours, the character cannot remember their own name.
- To extinguish the lamp, the character must give up something of equal value to what they originally paid (e.g., a cherished possession, a close relationship, a skill point).

Adventure Hook: A lighthouse keeper uses a lamp that never dies. But the keeper has forgotten his own daughter's name – and the sea is rising. The party must convince him to extinguish the light, or find a way to pay the Trow's price.

Colophon

Tavern corner, after midnight. The Trow smiled. Its teeth were grey. "I will take that question," it said. "You have already forgotten you asked it." I looked at my notes. The page was blank.

The Lamp

The Trow placed a finger on my page. "You wrote this," it said. "But you will not remember."

When I looked down, the ink was gone.

– *Trow's corner, hour unknown.*

24 **The Soup That Was Free**

Told by

Hag Morag (or so she called herself). She sat by a well, stirring a pot that had no fire under it. The soup was hot. She did not explain.

The Tale

A starving family came to a cottage. A crone answered the door. "I have soup," she said. "It is free."

They ate. The soup was rich, meaty, warm. They ate until they were full.

The crone watched. "The soup is free," she said again. "But the seconds will cost you."

The family hesitated. The father said, "We have no coin."

"I do not need coin," said the crone. "I need a breath. One breath from each of you. Hold it for me. I will give it back when you next share a meal."

They agreed. They breathed into her kettle. The kettle steamed.

They left. That night, they dreamed they were drowning. They woke gasping. Their breath was shorter.

They returned to the cottage. The crone was stirring the same pot. "The debt is not due yet," she said. "Eat again. The soup is still free."

They ate. They were not hungry. They ate anyway.

The crone took another breath. The kettle grew heavier.

For a year, they ate free soup once a week. Each time, the crone took a breath. Each time, their sleep grew deeper, their waking shorter.

On the last night, the father said, "We cannot pay. We have no breath left."

The crone nodded. "Good," she said. "Now you are honest. The debt is paid. The soup was the toll. The breaths were the interest. Go home. Cook your own meals."

They went home. They felt lighter. Their breath returned.

They never ate free soup again.

The Witch's Closing

"Free soup is a hook. The hook is not the soup. It is the second bowl."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Hungry Kettle

A pot that produces unlimited nourishing soup – but each bowl consumed also takes a small amount of breath (Fatigue). After enough bowls, the eater loses the ability to regain Fatigue naturally (they require magical healing or a specific service to the Hag).

Tags / Mechanics:

HEAL [CURSE]

- The soup restores 1 Supply per bowl. Each bowl also causes the eater to mark 1 Fatigue (which cannot be recovered by rest until the curse is lifted).
- Clock: *Hag's Debt* [4] – each bowl ticks once. When full, the eater must perform a favor for the Hag (or a hag of her choosing). Refusal causes the Fatigue to become permanent (cannot be healed).

Adventure Hook: A village has been living on free soup from a mysterious old woman. The villagers are growing weak, sleeping too much. The party must discover the price of the soup – and whether they can break the kettle without starving the village.

Colophon

Well at a crossroad. The crone winked. "You did not eat," she said. "That is good. I would have taken your ink."

The Kettle

The Hag tapped the pot. It rang like a bell. "Soup is ready," she said. "You are not hungry. That is wise."

– *Crossroad well, dusk.*

